

Giulia Ferrero

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Research interests

Primary Political Economy, Economic History and Development
Secondary Narratives, Media, Conflict, Gender

Education

PhD Candidate in Economics, Università di Torino and Collegio Carlo Alberto 2022 - Present
Doctoral Fellow at Collegio Carlo Alberto
Torino, Italy
Advisors: Elena Esposito and Giovanni Mastrobuoni

Visiting PhD Student Summer 2026
ENS Lyon - CERGIC
Lyon, France
Sponsor: Mathieu Couttenier

Visiting PhD Student May 2026
UCLA Anderson
Los Angeles, USA
Sponsor: Nico Voigtlander

CID PhD Fellow, Harvard Kennedy School Spring 2026
Center for International Development - Harvard Kennedy School
Boston, USA
Sponsor: Eliana La Ferrara

Second Cycle Master Degree in Economics (LMEC) 2018 – 2020
Alma Mater Studiorum - Università di Bologna - Final Grade: 110 cum laude
Bologna, Italy
Supervisors: Matteo Cervellati and Paolo Vanin
Master Thesis: “Organized Violence in a global perspective: an empirical investigation, 1989-2019”

Bachelor in Economics 2015 - 2018
University of Torino - Final Grade: 110 cum laude
Torino, Italy

Complex Network Analysis: Tools for Economic Development July 2023
Barcelona School of Economics (BSE)
Barcelona, Spain

Fellowships and Awards

Young Economist Best Presentation Award 2026
UniCredit Foundation and Harvard CID PhD Research Fellowship 2026
Scott Cunningham’s Mixtape Fellowship 2025

Working Papers

Wartime Narratives and Gender Norms (JMP)

Awarded the 2025 Mixtape Fellowship by Scott Cunningham

Governments have long used mass media narratives as a policy tool to shape social norms and behavior, yet causal evidence on the effects of such interventions remains scarce. This paper studies the case of the U.S. government’s coordinated media campaigns during World War II, which deliberately reshaped the public image of women to address wartime labor shortages. I construct a new dataset combining historical newspapers with a newly digitized archive of women’s magazines, which allows to trace changes in representations of women before, during, and after the war. Exploiting local variation in war-induced labor shortages and using an event-study design, I document a pronounced wartime shift toward portraying women as workers, followed by a rapid reversal once the war ended. While this narrative was short-lived, areas more exposed to wartime pressures experienced a persistent increase in the visibility of women in public discourse. To isolate the causal effect of media narratives from local labor market conditions, I combine historical survey data with a shift-share strategy based on magazine circulation and national changes in content. Exposure to wartime narratives significantly shaped postwar attitudes toward women’s roles and political participation, with effects that outlasted the economic shock itself. The results suggest that institutional messaging can rapidly reshape social narratives, even in non-authoritarian settings, with unintended consequences that may persist beyond the original shock.

Sons of War: the Effect of Conflict on Son Preference with Jessica Mancuso

Awarded the Grigor Artsruni Award at the Armenian Economic Association Conference in Yerevan

Armenia and Azerbaijan have experienced rising sex selection since the late 1980s, coinciding with the onset of the Nagorno-Karabakh conflict. In a setting marked by strong son preference and widespread reliance on abortion, we ask whether this conflict contributed to the rise in sex selection. We merge DHS data with two sources of conflict-related

casualties, UCDP data and a novel conflict exposure dataset, to investigate the effect of ethnic conflict on fertility decisions. To do so, we leverage variation in the geographic and temporal exposure to conflict-related violence during the First Nagorno-Karabakh War (1988–1994), alongside variation in the gender composition of children across families. We find that families with only daughters increase their fertility in the very short run following conflict exposure, and that this response is driven entirely by the birth of sons. Conflict thus intensifies son preference, manifesting in son-targeting fertility behavior and sex-selective abortion. We discuss three mechanisms: a marriage squeeze, child replacement among families who lost a son during the war and a broader identity-related motive.

Work in Progress

Narratives and Movies with Elena Esposito, Tiziano Rotesi and Alessandro Saia

Road to Socialism: media tycoons and policy outcomes with Elena Esposito

Conference and seminar presentations

- 2026 ENS Lyon CERGIC seminars, Alberto Alesina Graduate Student Workshop in Political Economy and Culture at Harvard University, 11th MPWZ-CEPR Text-As-Data Workshop, ESP Workshop at the Harvard Kennedy School, Graduate Workshop in Economic History - Harvard University, CID Research Xchange at Harvard Kennedy School
- 2025 2025 BAEM (Bristol Applied Economics Meetings) Workshop on Gender, Diversity and Human Capital, Fragile Lives 2025, VPDE 2025 internal PhD forum, Third Political Economy CCA-Cornell-Bocconi Winter Workshop (poster)
- 2024 VPDE 2024 internal PhD forum

Teaching

Econometric Theory I - graduate 2023-2025

Collegio Carlo Alberto - TA to Yagan Hazard

Microeconomics Spring 2024

SAA - School of Management TA to Nadia Campaniello

Professional Experience

Research Assistant for Elena Esposito (*CCA/UNITO*) 2023

Research Assistant for Margherita Fort and Michela Carlana (*UNIBO*) 2022

Trainee in DGI - External Developments (DG-I/EXT) - European central bank (*ECB*) 2021-2022

Research Assistant for Matteo Cervellati (*UNIBO*) 2020

Research Assistant for Luca Lambertini (*UNIBO*) 2019

Skills

IT knowledge Python, STATA, R, Latex, Qualtrics, QGIS, text analysis, web scraping, LLMs

Languages Italian (mother tongue); English (fluent)

References

Elena Esposito

Collegio Carlo Alberto, Junior Chair

Full professor in Economics

ESOMAS, Department of Economics

University of Torino

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Giovanni Mastrobuoni

Collegio Carlo Alberto, Carlo Alberto Chair

Full professor in Economics

ESOMAS, Department of Economics

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Scott Cunningham

Ben H. Williams Professor of Economics

Baylor University

Juan Vargas

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